# Eat With Joy Jerk Chicken and Pineapple Pico Bowls

Traeger Jerk Chicken over Jasmine Rice with Pineapple Pico, Cucumber-Avocado Salad, and Sweet Potato Tots



> *"Go your way, eat your bread with joy, and drink your wine with a merry heart; for Elohim has already accepted your works."*
> — *Kohelet* 9:7, *The Word of* יהוה

**Category:** Meats → Chicken
**Servings:** About 4 (1½ lb chicken). Double everything for 3 lb.
**Time:** 15 minutes prep the night before, overnight marinating, about 45 minutes the next day
**You'll need:** Traeger (or oven), a zip-top bag or covered glass dish, a rimmed tray, 2 mixing bowls, a spoon, plastic wrap, an air fryer, and an instant-read thermometer
**Clean eating:** Follows the Leviticus 11 rules for this book. Coconut-free.

## Ingredients

### Jerk Chicken

- 1½ lb boneless chicken thighs
- 2 tablespoons Adams Jamaican Jerk Seasoning
- 2 tablespoons olive oil
- 2 tablespoons fresh lime juice (about 1 lime)

### Pineapple Pico de Gallo

- About 1 cup fresh pineapple, cut in small ¼-inch pieces
- 1 jalapeño, seeds and ribs removed, finely chopped
- 2–3 tablespoons chopped red onion (H-E-B pre-chopped red onion works great)
- Chopped cilantro, measured with your heart (H-E-B pre-chopped cilantro works great)
- Juice of ½ lime
- A pinch of salt and pepper

### Cucumber-Avocado Salad

- 1 large cucumber
- 1 ripe avocado
- 1 tablespoon olive oil
- 2 tablespoons strawberry balsamic vinegar (from H-E-B; the pretty bottle with a strawberry on the front)
- Juice of ½ lime
- A pinch of salt and pepper

### To Serve

- 1 pouch ready jasmine rice (boil-in-bag or microwave)
- Sweet potato tots (about half a bag)

## Steps

### The Night Before: Marinate

1. **Drain the chicken.** Tip the package over the sink and carefully pour off the juices without splashing. Pat the chicken dry with paper towels.
2. **Mix the marinade.** In a bowl, stir the jerk seasoning, olive oil, and lime juice with a fork until there are no dry clumps.
3. **Watch your eyes.** Stir slowly and keep your face back from the bowl. Lime and jerk spice burn if they splash. If any gets in your eye, flush it with lukewarm water for 15 minutes.
4. **Coat the chicken.** Put the chicken in a zip-top bag or glass dish, pour the marinade over it, and massage or turn until every piece is coated.
5. **Refrigerate overnight.** Set the bag on a rimmed tray and refrigerate 8–24 hours. Never leave it on the counter. Overnight is what makes this chicken so good.

### The Next Day: Cook the Chicken

6. **Preheat.** Set the Traeger to **400°F** and let it fully heat, about 15 minutes. No Traeger? Use the oven at 425°F on a foil-lined sheet pan.
7. **Lay out the chicken.** With tongs, place the chicken flat on the grates. Throw away the leftover marinade; it touched raw chicken.
8. **Cook and flip.** Close the lid. Cook about 12–15 minutes, flip with tongs, then cook 10–15 more minutes. Plan on more than 8–10 minutes a side.
9. **Check the temperature.** Push the thermometer into the thickest piece. It's done at **165–175°F**. We pulled ours at 170°F and it was fantastic. Not there yet? Close the lid and check again every 5 minutes.
10. **Rest.** Move the chicken to a plate and let it rest 5 minutes so the juices stay inside.

### While the Chicken Cooks: Pico and Salad

11. **Make the pico.** In a bowl, mix the pineapple, jalapeño, red onion, cilantro, lime juice, salt, and pepper.
12. **Seed the cucumber.** Cut the cucumber in half the long way. Run a spoon down the center of each half to scoop out the seeds and soft middle, like gutting a jalapeño. This keeps the salad crisp.
13. **Cut the cucumber.** Cut each half in half again the long way (quarters), then cut across into ½-inch chunks.
14. **Dress the cucumber.** In a second bowl, toss the cucumber with the olive oil, strawberry balsamic, lime juice, salt, and pepper.
15. **Chill both.** Cover both bowls with plastic wrap and refrigerate until you eat. Sitting lets the flavors soak in.
16. **Start the sides.** Cook the ready rice by the package directions (boil-in-bag is about 10 minutes). Air-fry the sweet potato tots by the bag directions, shaking the basket halfway, until crisp and browned.

### Finish and Serve

17. **Add the avocado last.** Right before eating, cut the avocado into ½-inch chunks and gently fold it into the cucumber salad 4–6 times so it doesn't mash. Taste and add a pinch more salt or pepper if needed.
18. **Cube the chicken.** Cut the rested chicken into bite-size cubes.
19. **Build the bowls.** Put jasmine rice on the bottom, spoon the pineapple pico over it to make it pretty, then pile the chicken cubes on top.
20. **Add the sides.** Serve the cucumber-avocado salad and sweet potato tots on the side.

## Tips

- **Heat:** The jalapeño and jerk seasoning bring real heat. Use less or skip the jalapeño if you're sensitive to heat.
- **Want it spicier?** Leave some jalapeño seeds in the pico, or add a second jalapeño.
- **Cilantro:** Measure it with your heart. Love it? Add more. Not a fan? Leave it out.

## Clean-Eating Notes

- **Chicken:** Clean. It isn't on the forbidden bird list in VaYikra 11:13–19.
- **Coconut-free:** Check the jerk seasoning, sweet potato tots, and strawberry balsamic labels for coconut or coconut oil every time you buy them.
- **Jerk seasoning:** Some jerk blends and sauces contain fish sauce or shellfish. Adams Jamaican Jerk Seasoning is a dry rub; always check the label.

## Feast Suggestions

- **Sukkot:** Bright, fresh, and great for eating outside in the sukkah.
- **Shabbat:** Marinate Thursday night, cook Friday afternoon.

WHAT REALLY HAPPENED

# The Chicken That Spent the Night

*Or: how a burning eyeball, a nap, and a birthday party made the best chicken I've ever cooked.*

Let me tell you how this chicken got so good. It wasn't skill. It was chaos.

I'm standing at the counter, stirring jerk seasoning and lime juice like I know exactly what I'm doing, and that marinade jumps right out of the bowl and lands square in my eye. Lime. Jerk spice. Straight in the eyeball. Y'all. I flushed it out at the sink and stood there blinking like I'd just lost a fight with a seasoning bottle.

After a hit like that, a woman has earned a nap. So I took one.

Then it was time to go out for Gayla's birthday, and dinner? Dinner could wait. That chicken sat in the fridge all night long, soaking up every last bit of that marinade while we were out celebrating.

The next night I fired up the Traeger to 400, and while it heated up I threw together the pineapple pico and the cucumber salad, covered them, and let them chill. I'll be honest: I got a little lazy on the rice and grabbed the boil-in-a-bag kind. No shame. And Kevin's cucumbers got the seeds scooped out, because that man does not do squishy.

Rice on the bottom, pico on top, chicken cubed and piled high, cucumber salad and sweet potato tots on the side. It was pretty, it was healthy, and it was yummy, yummy chicken.

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Turns out the secret ingredient is a burning eye, a nap, and a birthday party. Or you could just marinate it overnight. Your call.

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— Alexis